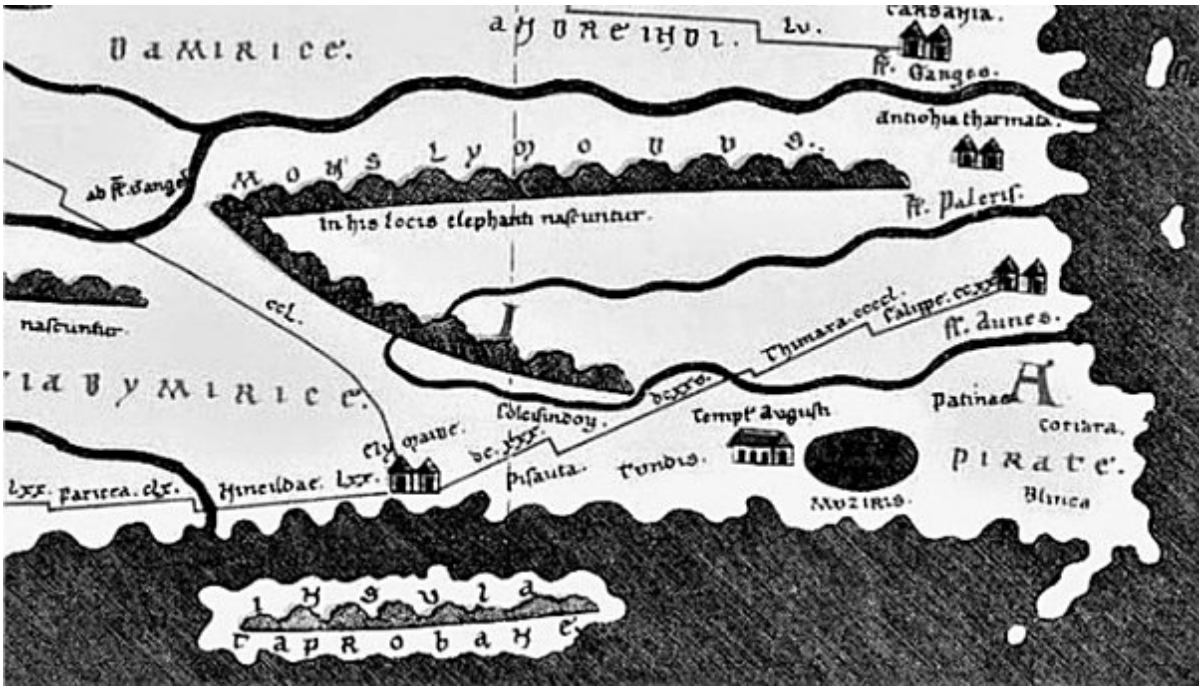


The bottom right corner of the last section of the *Tabula Peutingeriana*, showing the South Indian peninsula and Sri Lanka ('Insula Taprobane', or 'Island of Taprobane') at a time when the Satavahana rajas were the dominant powers in central and South India. The major trade port of Muziris is given prominence, with the temple of Augustus nearby and a lake representing what are now the Kerala backwaters.

But as the eye proceeds up the other coast it meets the most striking features of this corner of the map: a large lake coloured dark blue, 'Lacus Musiris', and under it in capitals MUZIRIS. On the left (north) side of the lake is a drawing of a classic Roman temple with columns and pediment and above it the inscription 'templum Augusti', or 'temple of Augustus'. We can interpret the lake as the famous backwater lagoons of Kerala, while Muziris can be matched to the port of Muciri, situated at the mouth of the Periyar River on the Malabar coast. The presence of an Augustan temple on Indian soil shows that in the first half of the first century CE there were enough Roman traders settled in Muciri for them to put up their own temple in the name of their ruling or recently deceased emperor.